



Unusual *alliances*

Getting along with your own species is one way of ensuring your survival. Another is to form a close alliance with another organism so that you both benefit. It really can pay to get along with your neighbors!

CLOSE FRIENDS

In some relationships between different species, only one half of the partnership benefits. The host species often provides food, a home, or

transportation for the other species, but doesn't suffer any harm from it. This type of relationship is called commensalism.

Some say he's only using me as bait for a bigger fish, but I FEEL SO SAFE in his protective arms.



It's great to catch the sun from up here. The view from this tree is SPECTACULAR.



This really is a comfy ride. And what's more, she NEVER COMPLAINS.



Clown fish make their home inside the tentacles of sea anemones. They are immune to the anemone's stings, which paralyze other fish, making it an ideal hiding place. The clown fish also benefits from scraps of food that the anemone misses. The anemone seems to get little more than some occasional cleaning, although the clown fish may act as bait for bigger fish.

Many orchids live high up on the branches of rainforest trees. They benefit by being much closer to the light than if they were on the forest floor. They cause no damage to the tree unless too many try to grow on it at the same time, when the weight may break the branches. They get all their water and nutrients from the air and rain, and sometimes from plant debris that accumulates on the branch.

Emperor shrimp live on sea slugs and sea cucumbers. They use them for shelter and transportation and feed on food disturbed by the host. It will even eat its host's poop. The shrimp also benefits from the poisonous reputation of sea slugs; predators avoid them. Emperor shrimp often change their color to match their host and camouflage themselves for extra protection.